

(3) Reformed Christianity (Calvinism)..(Reformed And Presbyterian Churches)

BRIEF INTRODUCTION

Reformed Christianity is a major Protestant denomination with approximately 75-80 million (2014 estimates) members worldwide. Reformed Christianity began in Switzerland in early 16th century (1522 C.E) when Roman Catholic priest Huldrych Zwingli (1484-1531) began to reform many of non-biblical teachings, practices and corruptions of Roman catholic Church. This movement got its solid footing with the work of John Calvin (1509-1564).

The reform movement led by Luther in Germany and Zwingli in Switzerland began independently around the same time. Zwingli was soon impressed and influenced by Luther. Zwingli's disagreement with Luther regarding "Real presence of Christ during the Lord's Supper" is the main reason behind the emergence of Lutheran and Reformed churches instead of one Protestant Church out of Protestant Reformation.

John Calvin's contribution was decisive and helped spread Reformed Christianity within Europe and beyond. Many reform-era theologians trained with Zwingli and Calvin then fanned out across Europe spreading the Reformed faith. One of them John Knox (1513-1572) brought and established reformed Christianity (Presbyterian) in Scotland. To this day (2014 CE) only Church of Scotland remains the dominant church (National Church) with majority of its population (34% 2014 estimates)being reformed protestant. Immigrants from Europe brought Reformed Christianity in North America.

Churches that follow Reformed Christianity (also known as Calvinism) in terms of their theology but differ in the form of church polity (governance)are the Presbyterian Church, the Congregational Church, the Dutch Reformed Church, and the German Reformed Church.

In our following discussion we will focus only on unique aspects of Reformed Christianity and where there are differences with other Protestant denominations. So it is important to read upon 'Branches of Christianity' and 'Protestantism' in our website before proceeding any further.

SOURCES OF RELIGIOUS/SACRED INFORMATION

Reformed Christianity (like all other Protestant denominations)only considers the holy Bible as the source of religious/sacred information.

Reformed Christians also accept the Westminster Confession of Faith, the Heidelberg Catechism, the Scots Confession and the Second Helvetic Confession as these relates teachings from the Bible.

KEY FEATURES OF BELIEF

(Only the unique features of Reformed Christianity are discussed in this section)

THE CHURCH

Most Reformed Churches use presbyterian polity (hence the name Presbyterian church) and few use congregational polity (hence the name Congregational church).

~~Church structure is usually plain and devoid of statues and images.

THE CLERGY

Today most Reformed/Presbyterian churches allow women to be part of the clergy. Most Churches nowadays also ordain homosexual clergy.

THE SACRAMENTS (OR ORDINANCES)

Reformed Christianity accept two sacraments: Baptism and Lord's Supper.

Baptism: They baptize both infants and adults.

Lord's Supper: Most Reformed Christians today side with the teaching of John Calvin who taught there is a real presence of Jesus in the elements (bread and wine), but it is a spiritual presence.

SALVATION

Reformed Christians believe falling away (loss of salvation) is not possible for a person who truly has been regenerated by God and will remain in God's stead.

STATUES AND ICONS (IMAGES)

Reformed Christians view range from total objection to very limited use of statues and images in their churches and lives.

CONTRACEPTION AND CONCEPTION

Historically opposed contraception but in modern times most churches allow some sort of contraception and some oppose contraception.

ABORTION

There is no unified position among all Reformed churches. Some churches allow abortion under certain circumstances and some do not allow abortion except in case of 'life of mother'.

DIVORCE AND REMARRIAGE

Churches allow divorce and remarriage under certain circumstances.

FOR MORE INFORMATION (Some Sources Used For This Article)

<http://www.patheos.com/Library/Presbyterian>

http://www.churchofscotland.org.uk/about_us

<https://www.presbyterianmission.org/ministries/today/what-do-presbyterians-believe/>

<http://christianity.about.com/od/presbyteriandenomination/p/presbyteprofile.htm>

<https://carm.org/calvinism>

<http://www.scfaith.org/about-faith-church/history>

<http://www.gotquestions.org/new-calvinism.html>

<http://www.theopedia.com/calvinism>